Anonymous — Chronicle of 1234 (Syriac, to AD 1234)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to the unknown author of the *Chronicle of 1234*. The record does not name him, and it holds no life for him at all. What remains is his work: a universal chronicle in Syriac, in two parts, carrying its history down to the year 1234, which survives from a single fourteenth-century manuscript discovered in Istanbul in 1899. The dedication is to that unnamed writer, for the history he set down.

The story

The author of this chronicle is not named in the record, and this edition credits the work exactly as the record does: as anonymous. What survives is a universal chronicle in Syriac, in two parts, carrying its history down to the year 1234, the date that gives the work its modern name.

A universal chronicle, in plain words, is a history that tries to cover the whole of the past known to its writer, not only the events of one kingdom or one lifetime. Part I of this chronicle treats early world history. Part II treats early Islam through the Crusades.

The whole work survives from a single manuscript of the fourteenth century,

discovered in Istanbul in 1899. That single-manuscript survival is central to its story. One copy carried a history of the world, from its earliest parts through the age of the Crusades, across the centuries between its writing and its rediscovery.

The record values the chronicle most highly as a primary source — an account from the period itself — for the Crusades and for Cilicia in the late twelfth and early thirteenth centuries. For an English reader, however, that source has been available only in a small portion. The chronicle's story in English is the story of one journal article's worth of translation standing in place of a book.

The work and what survives

The Syriac text was edited by J.-B. Chabot in the CSCO series — the *Scriptores Syri* III, volumes 14–15, also numbered CSCO 81–82 — published between 1916 and 1920. Chabot also supplied a Latin translation, published as CSCO 109 in 1937. A French translation of volume II, by Albert Abouna, was published at Louvain in 1974 as CSCO 354, and it is in copyright.

The public-domain position is stated by parts, and the parts differ. Chabot's Syriac edition of 1916–1920 is in the public domain by date. The Latin volume of 1937 needs a United States renewal check before reliance on it. Tritton and Gibb's English work of 1933, described below, likewise needs its own renewal check.

Those renewal cautions are part of the record, and they are not removed here. A date alone is not treated in this dossier as settling the position of the 1937 Latin volume or of the 1933 English articles.

Its English fortunes

No complete English translation found after research — partial English only.

The partial English consists of Tritton and Gibb, “The First and Second Crusades from an Anonymous Syriac Chronicle,” published in the *JRAS* in 1933, in two parts. Beyond that, the record notes Chabot's French piece on the fall of Edessa in 1144 — French, not English, and a piece, not the chronicle.

French readers have Abouna's translation of volume II, published in 1974 and in copyright. Latin readers have Chabot's translation of 1937, subject to the renewal check noted above. English readers have the Crusades excerpts of 1933.

What completing it would take

Completing it would take a book-length English translation made from the CSCO Syriac text, with Chabot's Latin translation used as a crib — a close guide standing beside the original. The Crusades sections already translated by Tritton and Gibb would be left out of the new work, since those sections already exist in English.

The result aimed at is one complete chronicle in English, where today only a journal article's worth exists.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chronicle_of_1234
- https://www.degruyterbrill.com/document/doi/10.31826/9781463222826/html